

Raptor Center's CEO enjoys her new workplace

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AMY BALDWIN

A dream job brought Joy Braunstein to Charlotte from Pittsburgh just before Labor Day.

Braunstein, 33, is the new CEO and president of the Carolina Raptor Center, located at the

Latta Plantation Nature Preserve in Huntersville. Most days – unless she has a meeting uptown – she gets to forgo a suit in favor of khaki and brown park ranger-like clothes. And her workplace, deep in the woods and home to injured and rehabilitated birds of prey, is “inherently tranquil.”

Previously, Braunstein worked for the United Jewish Federation of Pittsburgh, writing grants and overseeing projects, and before that did similar work as an environmental specialist for the U.S. Department of Interior, also in Pittsburgh.

“One of the really fantastic things about my move here is the opportunity to work in a park,” she said.

Braunstein spends a lot of off-hours at the park too. She boards two purebred horses – Hollywood and Melody – at Latta Equestrian Center and often hits the trails of Latta Plantation. But she also enjoys live music, art and theater.

“I can move easily from the woods and horseback ... to an art opening, musical or theater performance or wine bar,” she said.

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Joy Braunstein, who heads the Carolina Raptor Center, in her wooded surroundings with Sozo, a male screech owl that has an injured eye.

And, with a father who was a chef and restaurant consultant, Braunstein loves good food. She's pleased that Charlotte is a good food town. Two favorite restaurants so far: Dressler's in Birkdale Village and Customshop on Elizabeth Avenue near uptown. She recently met her mom, who lives in Winston-Salem and Boone, for dinner at Maddy's Southern Bistro in Birkdale.

As a child growing up in Taos, N.M., Braunstein spent a good bit of time in North Carolina, because her mother is from Hickory. In fact, her mom had been trying to get Braunstein to work at the raptor center ever since she got her undergraduate degree in outdoor environmental education from Johnson State College in Johnson, Vt.

Braunstein was reminded of that prodding more recently when she saw the center's job opening in an online posting. She figures this is where she's supposed to be.

She plans to stay in Charlotte indefinitely. She bought a house in the northwest part of town close to work.

For more info on the Carolina Raptor Center, go to www.carolinaraptorcenter.org.

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